

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Software Product Management English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

A/B test

Controlled comparison of two variants to estimate the effect of a change on a defined outcome.

acceptance criteria

Specific conditions a deliverable must meet to be accepted.

activation

The point at which a new user completes a defined first valuable action.

API

Application programming interface; a defined way for software systems to exchange data or trigger actions.

capacity

Available people, assets, time, space, or system throughput for a given workload.

cohort

A defined group sharing a characteristic or starting event for analysis over time.

decision memo

A concise document presenting a decision question, options, evidence, and recommendation.

definition of done

An agreed description of the work required before an item is considered complete.

dependency

Work, approval, input, vendor, system, or decision that another activity relies on.

edge case

An unusual or boundary condition a product or process may need to handle.

enablement

Resources and preparation that help a team perform a role effectively.

funnel

A sequence of stages people move through toward a defined outcome.

guardrail metric

A measure monitored to detect an unwanted consequence of an experiment or change.

hypothesis

A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence.

migration

Moving data, users, or operations from one system or arrangement to another.

opportunity cost

The value of the best alternative given up when choosing an option.

persona

A research-informed representation of a user group used to guide design or communication.

platform

A foundational technology or system that supports several applications or products.

prioritization

Deliberate ordering of work based on value, urgency, risk, capacity, and dependencies.

release

Authorization to make a product available or proceed to a next stage, depending on the field.

reliability

The ability to perform an intended function consistently under stated conditions over time.

retention

Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

roadmap

A plan showing intended product or organizational direction over time, with varying levels of commitment.

rollback

Returning a system or release to a previous state under an agreed process.

stakeholder

Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

statistical significance

A result meeting a specified statistical test threshold under its assumptions; it does not establish practical importance or causation.

strategic fit

How well an option supports an organization's objectives and capabilities.

technical debt

Future work arising from design or implementation choices that make later changes harder.

tradeoff

A choice that improves one objective while giving up something on another.

use case

A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

user need

Something a user needs to accomplish in a particular context.

user story

A concise description of a user's goal and the value a product capability should provide.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Product Discovery and Problem Framing

A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Roadmaps and Prioritization

A roadmap has three large features and capacity for two. All three sponsors describe their request as urgent.

We have capacity for two features in this period. Could we compare the expected outcomes and dependencies, then agree which item moves? Calling all three urgent does not resolve the capacity choice.

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | User Stories and Acceptance Criteria

A user story says the page should load "quickly." The team needs a testable completion condition.

Could we define the relevant user journey, measurement conditions, and acceptable response time? That will make the acceptance criteria clear enough for development and testing.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Metrics, Funnels, and Product Analytics

A product dashboard shows more sign-ups but fewer users completing setup. A stakeholder calls the acquisition campaign a complete success.

Sign-ups increased, but setup completion fell. These metrics describe different stages of the funnel. Let's examine the full journey before concluding that the change improved the intended user outcome.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Experimentation and A/B Testing

An A/B test shows a higher conversion rate in one version after one day. The planned test duration has not elapsed.

The early observed rate is higher, but the planned test is incomplete. I'll report it as an interim result and check the agreed analysis and guardrail measures before recommending a decision.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Release Readiness and Go-to-Market

A release is ready for review, but the support team has not received migration notes. The launch checklist lists them as required.

The product checks are ready for review; support preparation is still open. I'll send the migration notes and ask the support owner to confirm readiness before the launch decision.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Platform, APIs, and Technical Debt

A team can add a requested feature quickly using a workaround or spend longer improving the underlying interface.

The workaround is faster initially, while the interface change may reduce future maintenance. Let's compare delivery time, reliability, and ongoing cost instead of considering only the first release date.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Stakeholder Pushback and Executive Narrative

Two executives disagree about a product decision. The meeting has competing opinions but no shared criterion.

Could we agree on the outcome and decision criteria first? Then we can compare the options against them, record the tradeoff, and confirm who will make the final decision.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Software Product Management English

Professional audience: software product managers, product owners, UX leads, engineering managers, growth product teams, platform PMs, and product-operations staff

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Product Discovery and Problem Framing

Original fictional case: A stakeholder requests a new button without explaining the user problem. Support notes mention difficulty finding an existing action.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: user need: Something a user needs to accomplish in a particular context. / persona: A research-informed representation of a user group used to guide design or communication. / use case: A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal. / opportunity cost: The value of the best alternative given up when choosing an option.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and

an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What is the user trying to achieve, and where do they get stuck? Let's examine that problem before deciding whether a new button is the right solution.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level